Scorpene submarines. India received the price bids for the Rafale-Ms as well as three conventional submarines in December. The Rafale-M deal is processed through an inter-governmental agreement. The three-submarine deal is a follow-on to the earlier contract with France's Naval Group, under which the Mumbai-based Mazagon Dockyard Shipbuilders Ltd manufactured six Scorpene class submarines in India.

A panel of experts has now been set up to fix the benchmark price for the new submarines. "Naval Group has shared critical submarine technology and the MDL has learnt a lot during joint manufacturing. With the built-up infrastructure and expertise, delivery of the next three will be faster," says a defence official.

It is notable that France was the first country with which India established a "strategic partnership" in 1998, when then French president Jacques Chirac visited India as chief guest at the Republic Day parade. A strategic dialogue was initiated that same year. When India carried out nuclear tests at Pokhran that very year in May, France was the only P5 nation (one of the permanent members of the UN Security Council) to publicly support New Delhi. Similarly, in 1999, during the Kargil conflict, France openly held Pakistan responsible for their "dangerous initiative". Later, in 2008, after the Nuclear Suppliers Group waiver allowed India nuclear trade, France signed a civil nuclear pact with India. In addition, France has supported India in its initiatives on counter-terrorism in Kashmir.

In the light of all this, France is now considered a close ally of India. Indeed, its support as a P5 nation remains strategically significant for India. "India also is an equally important country for France vis-a-vis security in the Indian Ocean Region (IOR) and as a huge market. France considers India its interface with the Global South," says Lt Gen. Anil Ahuja (retd), former Deputy Chief of Integrated Defence Staff. France is willing to transfer technologies for defence systems that India needs to become self-reliant in the military sector, he adds. For instance, Safran Engines of France is helping Hindustan Aeronautics Ltd (HAL) in the development of engines for the under-development Indian Multi-role Helicopter. The French government has also given approval to Safran to jointly "design, develop, test, manufacture and certify" engines for India's fifth-generation stealth jet (Advanced Medium Combat aircraft or AMCA) and Twin-Engine Deck Based Fighter (TEDBF). In space technology, India and France are planning to develop a "constellation" of 8-10 satellites for maritime surveillance in the IOR.

Observers believe the partnership with France enhances India's footprint in the Indian Ocean through French bases and presence in the Reunion Islands, Caledonia, French Polynesia, Djibouti and UAE. Thus, through its strategic ties, India can secure its interests where it is not present in force. As the geopolitical puzzles of the future evolve, at least one piece of the jigsaw fits snugly. ■

FRENCH HUG

↘ French president Emmanuel Macron is chief guest at the 2024 Republic Day parade

↘ After Russia, France is India's second largest weapons supplier. India's latest purchases are to be Rafale-M jets, Scorpene submarines

↘ The two nations have a 'strategic partnership'. Paris has backed New Delhi on the global stage on many issues

Bangladesh prime minister Sheikh Hasina is set to create history as she begins her fifth term in office. She will be the longest-serving PM of Bangladesh. The result of Bangladesh's 12th general election was predictable following the boycott by the Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP), the main opposition party. The elections were free and fair with sporadic violence, though the 42 per cent voter turnout showed apathy among the people.

The BNP greeted the result by calling for a nationwide general strike. The BNP had boycotted the election in 2014 and failed miserably in 2018, blaming the Hasina government of massive rigging. This time around, it tried its best to put pressure on the government by calling for hartals and unleashing violence. These tactics failed to deter the Hasina government. One reason for the BNP's boycott is a leadership contest that would dilute the control of its exiled vice-chairman Tarique Rahman, apart from the fact that the BNP on its own cannot get a majority anymore. Its ally, the Jamaat-e-Islami, a collaborator of the Pakistani army in the genocide of 1971, remains banned.

Prior to the election, Hasina came under pressure from the West, which called for free and fair elections in public statements. The US was the

